

own sake. “We believe an ingredient is only ‘unusual’ until someone finds the right way to use it. India has an incredible pantry that traditionally belongs in kitchens rather than bars, and our approach is to translate these flavours into balanced, memorable cocktails.”

That philosophy is embodied in The Silk, one of the most talked about drinks from the bar’s Bird’s Eye View: Meghalaya Edition menu. Built with silkworm, *tungrymbai*, or fermented soyabean paste, Don Julio Reposado and coconut milk, it also incorporates silkworm salt as part of the final serve.

He admits that the word “silkworm” inevitably sparks curiosity. “Of course, the moment guests see ‘silkworm’ on the menu, they have questions! We clearly explain that it is a non-vegetarian cocktail, and for some guests that means they won’t order it, which we completely respect.”

Yet, he says, curiosity usually gives way to appreciation. “People often order it expecting something challenging or shocking, and then realise it’s actually smooth, savoury, and very balanced.”

80 | Elsewhere, bartenders are drawing inspiration from equally unexpected sources. At Heliconia, inside JW Marriott Goa, beverage manager Jitendra Bhandari created Kemuri by fat-washing gin with bacon before blending it with Campari and sweet vermouth. “The idea behind Kemuri was to create a cocktail that reflects Goa’s food culture in an unexpected way. Pork is an integral part of Goan cuisine, so rather than simply pairing a drink with it, we wanted to incorporate its essence into the cocktail itself,” he says.

At PCO in New Delhi, general manager Vikas Kumar found inspiration in an ingredient rarely associated with fine drinking. “While researching ingredients for our Forbidden Menu, we discovered that *chyawanprash* has been banned in Canada for years. It immediately sparked an idea. I’d always felt *chyawanprash* had the complexity and depth to play a role similar to bitters in a classic cocktail like a Manhattan.” The resulting ‘Ignorance is Bliss’ combines bourbon, *chyawanprash*, coffee, sweet vermouth, and bitters, finished with edible gold leaf.

Its appeal has travelled well beyond India. “When I served it during our guest shift in

